Paper Things

By Jennifer Richard Jacobson

(Pg 105-106) Ever since I can remember, I've had this theory that when each person is born, he or she is given an imaginary sack with the same number of happy moments, horrible-news moments, and please-let-me-die-now embarrassments. So, while some people may have a bunch of bad moments all in a row, in the end, we'll all be even.

[My friend] Sasha tells me that's a ridiculous way of thinking. "Think of people who are starving, or who live in countries where there is war. They suffer more."

But I like to think that even those people might get to experience the same number of joys in their lives as everyone else. And on the flip side, people whose lives seem perfect might also be suffering in ways we don't see.

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But maybe [she's] right. Maybe that is a ridiculous way of thinking. Yet sometimes, when it feels like all my troubles are piling up - Mama getting sick and dying, Janna and Gage fighting all the time, maybe missing out on the chance to go to Carter - it helps to think that there are only so many bad times in my sack. That sooner or later the good things will have to take over.

INTRODUCTION

Family is important, but at what price? Before Ari's mother died, she made Ari promise to stick with her older brother, Gage. So when Gage decides he can no longer live with their bossy guardian, Janna, Ari leaves with him. There's just one problem - they have nowhere to go. Couch-surfing between friends' apartments and homeless shelters, Ari struggles to stay strong for her brother and keep up with schoolwork in order to be accepted into the prestigious Carter Middle School. Through this heart-wrenching struggle of homelessness, view one child's experience in the novel "Paper Things" by Jennifer Richard Jacobson.

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KEISHA: **(Pg 127)** "Is Ari using some new product in her hair? Or is that… ***grease***?"

LINNIE: **(Pg 128-129)** "She smells, too."

Is she joking? I put my head down just a little lower, trying to smell my pits. She's not joking, I stink.

How could I help it? The bus stop was practically a whole mile away from where [Gage and I] slept last night. I was running as fast as I could, but my shoe has started to flap where the stitching is coming out, and it falls off easily.

(Pg 6-7) I look over at Sasha's desk - something I do about fifty times a day - but she's not in her seat. My best friend is down on Walnut Street, acting as one of the safety patrol leaders. It's one of the fifth-grade leadership roles. You have to demonstrate leadership to get into Carter Middle School.

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Two months of school to go and I still haven't been chosen to do any of the leadership jobs. Not safety patrol, not tutoring, not shelving books in the media center. And I ***have to*** get into Carter. ***Have to.***

Only problem is, it's a school for the starry gifted, and I seem to have lost all my shine.

[Why does Carter matter so much to me anyway?] **(Pg 86-87)** Mama wanted me to attend Carter. It had been one of [her] dying wishes. Everyone in my family went to Carter - Mama, Dad, Gage, even Janna.

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(Pg 24) "What do you need for homework?" Gage asks when he picks me up at Head Start **(Pg 163)** I volunteer there in the afternoons.

ARI: **(Pg 24)** Library; I need to research a famous American. **(Pg 9)** My social studies grade is

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the pits. I did lousy on both quizzes and I haven't been able to finish the outline of my biography.

(Pg 27) [When we get there], Gage marches directly to the *Maine Times* to read the want ads, like he does every time we come. He doesn't have a regular job but goes wherever someone needs him. Lobstermen are always glad to see him on fish market days. Tomorrow he'll probably be the dishwasher at the nursing home

(Pg 28) I hope Gage finds a full-time job soon. What he didn't realize when we left Janna's is that landlords won't rent to you if you don't have a regular paycheck, no matter how much you've saved for the first and last month's rent. **(Pg 77-78)** Who is hiring? Jiffy Lube, but Gage says they want someone with experience.

It's not that Gage doesn't ***want*** to work - he works harder than anyone. And he really, really wants to get a job so we can get an apartment. It's

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just that he hates it when he asks and people tell him no.

(Pg 252-253) I pull out my application to Carter. There they are again - those spaces on the application that demand an address. I suppose I could write in Brigg's address, [Gage's friend from school], but that might get him in trouble. I could put Chloe's address, [Gage's girlfriend], but what if Gage and Chloe break up? I could write in Janna's address, but the last thing I want is my acceptance or rejection letter being sent to Janna's place.

We need an apartment! We need to figure this out!

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(Pg 262-263) The line outside the soup kitchen isn't long [tonight]. I'm standing behind Gage, waiting to enter the basement of the stone church and thinking about the first question on the Carter Middle School application: ***How would other***

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people describe you? I try to think of one-word answers that people I know might give:

Persistent. Hardworking. Disappointing. Sneaky.

(Pg 265) And that's when I see Keisha [from my class], standing at the back of the room, volunteering, ladling soup to the masses. Volunteering at the soup kitchen o n the exact night Gage and I decide to come by.

ARI: *(to Gage)* I'm not hungry - I don't feel good – I'll wait outside.

(Pg 268-269) The last thing I need is for word to get out that I eat at the soup kitchen. People would start asking questions, or start gossiping about me being dirty, smelly, ***and*** someone who eats with the homeless.

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(Pg 285) "We're not homeless," I [tell myself], but what does it mean to be homeless?

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I think of the people that I pass on the streets, the ones who are huddled against buildings or standing on curbs, asking for money, sometimes talking to themselves. ***They're*** homeless. I think of the girls at the Lighthouse who talk about which shelters had the nicest beds. ***They're*** homeless, too.

Homeless people are people who don't have homes. . . Like us, I realize.

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MS. FINCH: (Pg 295-297) *(waking Ari in class an speaking softly)* Ari, would you mind staying for a few minutes at the end of class?

When it's just me and Ms. Finch, she walks over to her desk and retrieves a paper bag from the bottom drawer.

MS. FINCH: "You see, I bought my niece a new pair of shoes, but they didn't fit her. If you

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like them and they fit, you're welcome to have them."

(Ari holds them in both hands, her mouth hanging open) My fingers barely work as I pull off my old shoes, and I wonder if ***everyone*** has noticed how ratty they are.

Maybe this is an act of charity, but I decide I don't care why Ms. Finch is giving them to me. I'm just grateful that she is.

And suddenly I'm crying.

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(Pg 301) ***Stay together always.*** That's what Mama said. That was the promise! But I think that both Gage and I know deep down that it's not the promise that's making us hold on to each other so tightly. It's the fear of letting go.

(Pg 307-308) Before I really even know what I'm doing, I pick up the phone and dial Janna's

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number. Gage will be mad . . . and hut. But I've made up my mind. I'm going home.

When [she] picks me up and I grab my backpack, she says, "Is that all you need?"

I nod but think ***no***. No, I need so much more than what is in my backpack. I need a homemade dinner, a warm shower, shampoo that smells like strawberries, a cozy bed. I need a place to keep my things, a place to do homework. I need a routine, a regular bedtime. I need rules, all 465 of them!

[Later, Gage comes to Janna's to check on me.]

ARI: **(Pg 314)** I need you to know something. *(takes a deep breath)* I didn't call Janna because I didn't want to be with you anymore. I loved being with you. But here at Janna's . . . here I get to be a kid. Just a kid.

GAGE: **(Pg 245)** It's not your fault. It's mine. I'm the one who lied to Janna and said we had

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an apartment. I'm the one who dragged you all over the city, carrying all your belongings in your backpack. I'm the one who can't give you more than Cheerios for breakfast and lunch.

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(Pg 344) That night, I work on the application for Carter Middle School. Fortunately the blanks for address and name of guardian are now easy to fill in. For one of the questions, I write about my experience working with the kids at Head Start.

I stare at the last question, the one that basically asks you to describe what sets you apart from your peers, what makes you special - what makes you Carter material.

(Ari takes a deep breath and begins writing) **(Pg 336)** I know what it's like to be an outsider, to feel like you don't belong. For six weeks, my brother and I were homeless. We slept on couches and at

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the shelter and even in a car. We did the best we could. I was too embarrassed to tell anyone what was going on. I didn't want to be different.

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(Pg 367-368) Everyone said that we would get our letters from Carter on Saturday. So imagine my surprise when I get home on Friday and there is the letter on the counter.

(Ari opens the letter and reads): "Dear Ms. Hazard, It is with great pleasure that we offer you a place at Carter Middle School for the next three years…"

I got into Carter. Despite the dip in my grades. Despite telling the application people about being homeless. Despite it all - or maybe, really, because of it all - I've been accepted.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jennifer Richard Jacobson
ISBN: 978-0763663230
Publisher: Candlewick Press
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2015

Cutting compliments of
Heather Whitney, Norfolk Public Schools, NE

**With minor adjustments by the 4N6 Fanatics staff to ensure correlation with the original text.*

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